



Acer Aspire 3684NWXCi

Good for the price

The Aspire 3684NWXCi laptop is for value-conscious buyers. With a silver-and-black exterior, it looks quite presentable. Though slim in design, the Acer 3684 weighs in at 2.4 kg—moderately heavy.

Ergonomically speaking, the keyboard is well laid-out; however, the keystrokes are bit hard—touch typists should try it before deciding to buy it.

An Intel Celeron M 440 at 1.86 GHz runs the laptop, and that's partly responsible for the low price. The Aspire 3684 has 512 MB of DDR2 RAM—we're all praise for Acer for being so generous! Having an 80 GB hard drive with a Combo DVD / CD drive is praiseworthy, considering the price.

In PC Mark 05—a synthetic test that measures overall system performance—performance was decent; the score was 2121, good for a budget-category laptop. 388 points in 3D Mark 06 means the laptop is good enough for games like *Quake 3*, *Counterstrike: Source*, and *Call of Duty*. Our real-world tests revealed enough power to multi-task between regular applications such as media players, word processing applications, browsers, etc.

The six-cell Li-ion battery pack managed to power the Aspire 3684 for 2:18 hours—which is reasonable, but

expect more time in real-world usage because our battery test is gruelling.

HD video playback (1080p WMV) is smooth.

The widescreen 14.1 inch TFT renders sharp images with good contrast. Acer doesn't miss out on connectivity options in this budget offering—you get wired and wireless networking as well as Bluetooth.

The Aspire 3684 comes pre-loaded with Linpus

Linux, which has a command-line interface... thankfully, Acer does bundle Windows XP and Vista drivers alongside just in case you feel like installing (an original copy of) Windows.

Priced at Rs 23,499, we think the Aspire gives local brands a run for their money. The lack of a proper OS is the only chink in its armour; otherwise, every thing seems to be on target for the value-conscious.

Specifications

Intel Celeron M440; 512 MB DDR2 533 MHz; 14.1-inch widescreen TFT; DVD/CD-RW Combo drive; 80 GB SATA hard disk; Dimensions: 14.3 x 10.8 x 1.3 (W x D x H) inches; Weight: 2.4 kg

Contact: Acer India Pvt Ltd
Phone: 080-25219520 / 23
E-mail: rajesh.aiyar@acer.co.in
Web site: www.acer.co.in
Price: Rs 23,499

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★☆
Performance	★★★★☆
Build Quality	★★★★☆
Value for Money	★★★★☆
Overall	★★★★☆

BlackBerry Curve 8300

Business with pleasure

The BlackBerry (BB) Curve 8300 is the littler sibling of the BB 8800, which we tested in August 2007. Most phones from RIM are business-centric, but the Curve incorporates multimedia features.

Silver tones make for a cool, refined look. The slim profile means the Curve 8300 is very comfortable to hold and carry around.

It's full-QWERTY keys are small yet well-spaced out. Tactile response is brilliant.

The 2.5-inch 320 x 240 screen is adequately large and the image is crisp—good enough for the intended use: primarily as a PDA-phone. The 2MP camera gave us good results in daylight, but in low-lit conditions, the images were washed-out. The flash tends to over-

saturate the subject to some extent in close-ups.

The mini USB port doubles up as a charging point. You can use the device for mass storage and access the 64 MB of internal memory; memory expansion is possible via the micro SD slot. The micro SD slot, being under the battery compartment, isn't hot-swappable.

Media Manager, based on Roxio software, comes with the BlackBerry Desktop Manager suite. This allows RIM to integrate multimedia technology and capabilities



like ripping audio CDs to the phone, managing playlists on it, and more. BB 8300 Curve comes with the personal manager and organiser apps that most smartphones come with. Synchronise the calendar, memo, task-list, etc. with your PC via Bluetooth or USB, or even with your corporate network if your

company runs a BlackBerry Enterprise Server.

The speaker-independent voice dialling application called VoiceSignal works really well. The 8300 performed well in our network reception test, with very few call drops. There is no Wi-Fi or 3G support.

Priced at Rs 24,990, the BB Curve 8300 is a good buy for those who demand executive features (PDA functionality) and a bit of multimedia; however, lack of Wi-Fi should be noted.

Specifications

Dimensions: 107 x 60 x 15 mm; Weight: 111 gm; Quad-band, Display: 2.5-inch, 320 x 240, 16-bit; Expansion slot: Micro SD; Camera: 2MP; GPRS; EDGE

Contact: Research in Motion
Phone: 9892577010/9920055666
E-mail: blackberry.mumbai@airtel.in
Web site: www.blackberry.com
Price: Rs 24,990

RATINGS	
Performance	★★★★☆
Features	★★★★☆
Ease of use	★★★★☆
Value for Money	★★★★☆
Overall	★★★★☆